



△ Cameo-carved portrait with distinct blue sheen

# Moonstone

**M**oonstone, an opalescent variety of anorthoclase and other feldspars, has been used in jewellery for centuries. Ancient Romans believed it came from solidified rays of the moon, and linked it to their lunar deities. Typically made up of layers of sodium- and potassium-rich feldspars, moonstone has a blue or white sheen – the result of the scattering or reflection of light by tiny intergrowths of minerals. The gem marketed as “rainbow moonstone” is more properly classified as a colourless labradorite (see p.169).

## Specification

**Chemical name** Sodium potassium silicate (Anorthoclase)  
**Formula**  $(\text{Na},\text{K})\text{AlSi}_3\text{O}_8$  | **Colour** Colourless, white  
**Structure** Triclinic | **Hardness** 6–6.5 | **SG** 2.6  
**RI** 1.50 | **Lustre** Vitreous | **Streak** White | **Locations**  
 India, Sri Lanka, Tanzania, Kenya, New Zealand, Australia, Norway

## Rough



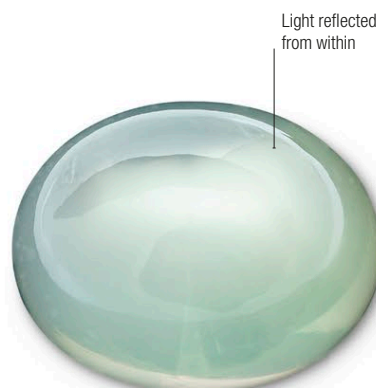
**Rounded pebble** | The pitted surface of this water-worn moonstone pebble has the appearance of frosted glass. The best gem material is often found in this form.

Delicate shine caused by interference between light rays



**Shimmering stone** | In this specimen, each layer of feldspar reflects light, which causes a soft sheen or bright iridescence to shimmer with an ethereal glow.

## Cut

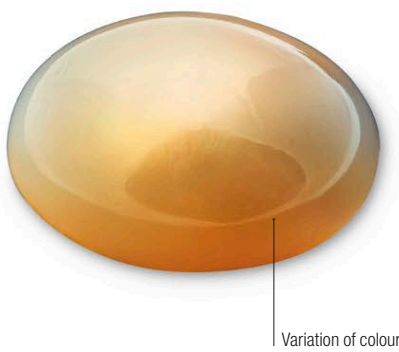


**Oval cabochon** | With a high dome and subtle iridescence, this moonstone is excellent quality. Moonstone is mainly cut *en cabochon* to bring out the sheen.



**Cameo carving** | The iridescence of moonstone adds shadows and highlight to carvings, giving an impression of depth, as in this example.

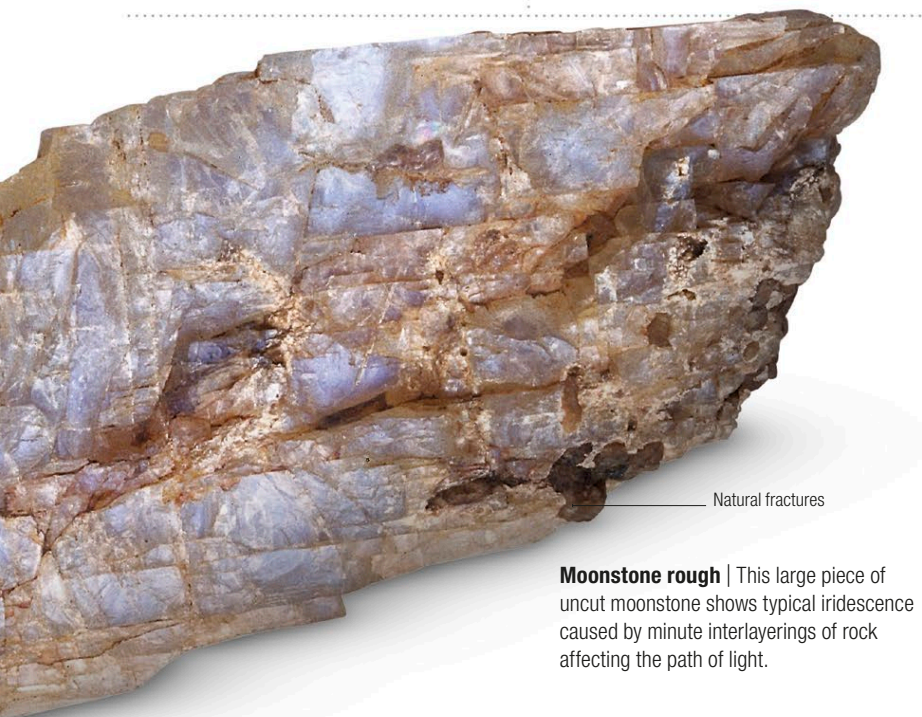
## Colour



**Unusual hue** | This cabochon has a dark honey tint to the base material combined with typical light iridescence like the shine of the moon after which moonstone is named.



**Blue transparency** | This unusually fine moonstone cabochon cut from a near-transparent rough has a bluish iridescence that makes the stone glow.



**Moonstone rough** | This large piece of uncut moonstone shows typical iridescence caused by minute interlayerings of rock affecting the path of light.